unimaginable violation of human rights. During the times of war, human lives lost its value and those affected by war had to struggle till the end of their life. Atrocities during the Second World War made clear that previous efforts to protect individual rights from government violations were inadequate. The rights of man were prevented or eliminated in several parts of the world due to several factors. It is proved that the government of some countries alone could not protect human rights. People wanted to ensure that never again would anyone be unjustly denied life, freedom, food, shelter, and nationality. These voices played a critical role in the San Francisco meeting in which the United Nations Charter was drafted in 1945. At this juncture, an International body, the United Nations Organisation (UNO) which was established on 24th October 1945 took up the issue. Human Rights is an important theme in all UN policies and programmes in the areas of peace and security, development, humanitarian assistance and economic and social affairs.

c. The Universal Declaration of Human Rights (UDHR)

One of the greatest achievements of United Nations is the creation of human rights law. To advance this goal, the UN established a Commission on Human Rights. The Commission guided by Eleanor Roosevelt's (wife of former US president Franklin D Roosevelt) forceful leadership captured the world's attention. Finally, the Universal Declaration of Human Rights (UDHR) was adopted by the UN General Assembly in 1948. It is a milestone document in the history of Human rights. The Declaration was proclaimed by the UN General Assembly in Paris, France on 10th December 1948(General Assembly resolution 217A). In remembrance of every year 10th December is observed as the Human Rights Day and its regular observance commenced from 1950. It is also known as modern International Magna Carta of Human Rights. Its principles have been incorporated into the Constitutions of most of the (more than 185) nations. UDHR has been translated into more than 500 languages. It is the most translated document in the world.

Preamble of UDHR

All men are born free and all are equal in status and rights. They are endowed with intelligence and conscience and obliged to promote the spirit of common brotherhood amongst all men.

The Cyrus Cylinder 539 BC (BCE)



Cyrus the Great, the first king of ancient Persia, freed the slaves and declared that all people had the right to choose their own religion and established racial equality. These and other decrees were recorded on a baked-clay cylinder in the Akkadian language in cuneiform script. It is translated into all six official languages of the United Nations and its provisions parallel the first four Articles of the Universal Declaration of Human Rights.

Human Rights are based on the values of

a. Dignity – The right to life, the right to integrity, the prohibition of enforced labour, slavery and degrading punishment.

b. Justice – The right to fair trial, proportional punishment to crime, the right not to be trialed more than once for the same crime

c. Equality – Equality before law. No discrimination on race, religion, gender, age, ability/disability etc.

Basic Characteristics of Human Rights

Inherent – they are not granted by any person or authority.

Fundamental – they are fundamental rights because without them, the life and dignity of man will be meaningless

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